

DIGITAL ART LAYER MODES GUIDE

Cheat Sheet • Mega Table • Visual Diagram • Beginner Guide

Programs: Procreate • Adobe Photoshop • Adobe Fresco • Clip Studio Paint

1. CHEAT SHEET — Layer Modes & Features

Darkening Modes

- **Multiply** — darkens while preserving hue (shadows)
- **Linear Burn** — stronger darkening (dramatic shading)
- **Color Burn** — high-contrast darkening (stylized shadows)

Lightening Modes

- **Screen** — soft lightening (highlights)
- **Add / Linear Dodge** — intense glow (magic, neon)
- **Color Dodge** — bright + saturated (fire, bloom)

Contrast Modes

- **Overlay** — boosts contrast (color grading)
- **Soft Light** — gentle contrast (skin, soft shading)
- **Hard Light** — strong contrast (stylized lighting)

Color Modes

- **Hue** — changes hue only
- **Color** — applies hue + saturation
- **Saturation** — modifies saturation
- **Luminosity** — modifies brightness

Layer Features

- **Alpha Lock** — paint only on existing pixels
- **Clipping Mask** — non-destructive shading
- **Layer Mask** — non-destructive erasing
- **Adjustment Layer** — color/tonal edits
- **Vector Layer** — crisp, editable strokes

2. MEGA-TABLE — All Programs Compared

Layer Mode / Feature	Definition	Properties	Application	Procreate	Photoshop	Fresco	CSP
Multiply	Darkens by multiplying colors	Keeps hue, adds density	Shadows	✓	✓	✓	✓
Add	Adds light values	Very bright	Glow, magic	✓	As Linear Dodge	✓	✓
Screen	Lightens by inverting multiply	Soft	Highlights	✓	✓	✓	✓
Overlay	Contrast boost	Saturation + contrast	Color grading	✓	✓	✓	✓
Soft Light	Gentle contrast	Subtle	Skin, soft light	✓	✓	✓	✓
Alpha Lock	Lock transparency	Pixel-only	Shading	✓	✓ (Lock Transparency)	✓	✓

Layer Mode / Feature	Definition	Properties	Application	Procreate	Photoshop	Fresco	CSP
Clipping Mask	Clip to layer below	Non-destructive	Shading, textures				
Layer Mask	Grayscale transparency	Editable	Clean edges	✓	✓	✓	✓
Adjustment Layer	Non-destructive color edits	Stackable	Curves, Hue/Sat	✗	✓	✗	✓ (Tonal Correction)
Vector Layer	Resolution-independent	Editable strokes	Lineart	✗	✓ (Shape layers)	✓	✓

3. VISUAL DIAGRAM – Blend Mode Families

BLEND MODE FAMILIES

GROUP	MODES	TYPICAL USE
DARKEN GROUP	Multiply, Burn	Shadows, Ambient Occlusion
LIGHTEN GROUP	Screen, Add	Highlights, Glow Effects
CONTRAST GROUP	Overlay, Soft Light	Color grading, texture boost
COLOR GROUP	Hue, Color, Saturation	Color manipulation
SPECIAL MODES	Difference, Exclusion	Stylized effects

4. BEGINNER-FRIENDLY GUIDE

Shadows

Use **Multiply** for:

- clothing folds
 - ambient occlusion
 - soft shadows
- Tip: opacity 20–40%.

Highlights

- **Screen** → soft light
- **Add** → strong glow

Color Grading

- **Overlay** → contrast boost
- **Soft Light** → subtle mood

Clean Workflow

- **Clipping Mask** → shading without damaging base
- **Alpha Lock** → recolor shapes
- **Layer Mask** → erase non-destructively

Lineart

Use **Vector Layers** (Fresco, CSP) for:

- comics

- manga
- clean strokes

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